

A Practical Love Publication

Five Global Evil Giants

Brethren, the time of ignorance has passed; we are living in the time of knowledge, for we serve the God of knowledge. A study edition with explanations.

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Practical Love Publications

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About This Study Edition

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

FIVE GLOBAL EVIL GIANTS

Brethren, the time of ignorance has passed; we are actually living in the time of knowledge. For we serve the God of knowledge.

This booklet is a study edition of *Five Global Evil Giants*, a short leaflet from Practical Love Publications. The leaflet is only a few lines long. It opens with a word of challenge to the church, names five great evils that trouble the whole world, gives Bible references for each one, and then offers a plan for fighting them. It ends by stating which parts of that plan this ministry has taken as its own concern. Short as it is, the leaflet carries a full message, and this edition sets out to open that message up so that it can be read slowly, understood clearly and put into practice.

How this edition is put together

Throughout the booklet you will find boxed passages marked “From the original leaflet”. These give the leaflet’s wording as it was printed, with spelling and punctuation lightly corrected and arrow symbols replaced by dashes. Everything else – the explanations, background notes, practical steps and questions – is study notes prepared by Practical Love Publications to explain and apply the teaching. These notes are not the original author’s own words. Where the leaflet only names a point or gives a Bible reference, the notes explain what that point means without adding stories or claims that the leaflet does not make.

Scripture quotations in the notes are from the King James Version (KJV). You are encouraged to keep your own Bible open as you read, to look up the passages around each verse, and to check that the explanations are faithful to God’s Word.

How to use this study

- **Personal reading.** Read one section at a time with your Bible open, look up every reference, and write down one thing you will do as a result.
- **Family devotion.** Read the boxed leaflet text and one or two Bible passages aloud, then let each member of the household answer one of the questions.
- **House fellowship or church study group.** Let a leader read the boxed text, ask different members to read the Scriptures, and use the questions at the end of each section for discussion and prayer.
- **One section per sitting.** There are ten sections. Taking one each day or each week gives time for the teaching to settle and for the practical steps to be tried.

Why call them “giants”?

In the Bible a giant is more than a tall man. When Moses sent twelve men to spy out the land of Canaan, most of them came back frightened by what they had seen. Their report is recorded in Numbers 13.

And there we saw the giants, the sons of Anak, which come of the giants: and we were in our own sight as grasshoppers, and so we were in their sight.

Numbers 13:33 (KJV)

Notice the words “in our own sight as grasshoppers”. The giants were real, but the greater problem was how small the spies felt in front of them. Caleb, who with Joshua trusted God, answered, “Let us go up at once, and possess it; for we are well able to overcome it” (Numbers 13:30). Many years later, in 1 Samuel 17, the giant Goliath of Gath came out morning and evening to defy the armies of Israel, and the soldiers fled from him in fear, until a young shepherd named David stepped forward in the name of the LORD.

The leaflet uses this picture for five problems that are bigger than any one person, family or government. They are *global* because they are found in every nation, rich or poor. They are *evil* because they spoil what God made good – the human soul, the community, the body and the mind. Like Goliath, they can make God’s people feel like grasshoppers. The purpose of this study is to help you see these giants clearly, understand what the Bible says about each one, and take your place among those who face them in faith.

A time of knowledge

The leaflet begins, “Brethren, the time of ignorance has passed.” This echoes two truths from Scripture. The first is about the character of God. When Hannah brought the young Samuel to the house of the LORD at Shiloh, as she had vowed, she prayed and declared:

Talk no more so exceeding proudly; let not arrogancy come out of your mouth: for the LORD is a God of knowledge, and by him actions are weighed.

1 Samuel 2:3 (KJV)

The God we serve knows all things, and He does not want His children to live in darkness about Him, about themselves or about the world He has placed them in. The second truth comes from Paul’s sermon to the philosophers of Athens:

And the times of this ignorance God winked at; but now commandeth all men every where to repent:

Acts 17:30 (KJV)

Paul’s first point is that the coming of Jesus Christ has changed the situation of the whole world. Before, the nations groped in darkness; now the light of the gospel has come, and God commands all people everywhere to repent and turn to Him. The leaflet’s opening words carry the same principle more widely: God has given His people His Word and His Holy Spirit, and also teachers, schools, books and many other means of learning, so there is no longer any excuse for carelessness. To live as if we were still in

the time of ignorance is to waste what God has given.

Overview of the whole message

The study follows the leaflet's own order:

1. Giant 1 – Spiritual Lostness: people separated from God (Luke 19:10).
2. Giant 2 – Corrupt Leadership: leaders who serve themselves instead of the people (Matthew 15:14).
3. Giant 3 – Poverty: how want comes, and the Christian response (Proverbs 24:33-34; 28:19).
4. Giant 4 – Disease: Jesus' ministry of healing and the church's care for the sick (Matthew 4:23).
5. Giant 5 – Ignorance: the danger of not knowing (2 Corinthians 2:11; Daniel 12:4).
6. Combating the Giants – The PEACE Plan: the strategy the leaflet offers for fighting the giants, followed by each of its five letters explained.
7. Our Concern: why this ministry gives special attention to churches, healing and education, and how you can take part.
8. Facing Your Giants: David's five smooth stones, a prayer and a closing commitment.

The giants are real, but our God is greater – and He calls His people out of ignorance into knowledge.

Giant 1: Spiritual Lostness

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

1. Spiritual Lostness – Luke 19:10

For the Son of man is come to seek and to save that which was lost.

Luke 19:10 (KJV)

The story behind the verse

Luke 19:10 is the closing sentence of the story of Zacchaeus. Zacchaeus lived in Jericho. He was the chief among the tax collectors, called publicans, and he was rich (Luke 19:2). Publicans collected taxes for the Roman authorities, and many enriched themselves by taking more than was due, so the people regarded them as sinners and traitors. Zacchaeus was also "little of stature", and when Jesus passed through the town he ran ahead and climbed a sycomore tree to see Him (Luke 19:3-4). Jesus stopped under that very tree and called him by name.

And when Jesus came to the place, he looked up, and saw him, and said unto him, Zacchaeus, make haste, and come down; for to day I must abide at thy house. And he made haste, and came down, and received him joyfully. And when they saw it, they all murmured, saying, That he was gone to be guest with a man that is a sinner. And Zacchaeus stood, and said unto the Lord; Behold, Lord, the half of my goods I give to the poor; and if I have taken any thing from any man by false accusation, I restore him fourfold. And Jesus said unto him, This day is salvation come to this house, forsomuch as he also is a son of Abraham.

Luke 19:5-9 (KJV)

Zacchaeus had money, position and influence, yet Jesus described him as lost. That tells us something important: lostness is not first about being poor, uneducated or disreputable. It is about being away from God. A sheep may be healthy and well fed and still be lost if it has wandered from its shepherd. The crowd murmured because they thought some people were too sinful to deserve a visit from Jesus. Jesus answered that finding such people was exactly why He came.

What spiritual lostness means

The Bible teaches that every human being, without exception, begins in this condition.

For all have sinned, and come short of the glory of God;

Romans 3:23 (KJV)

To be lost is to be separated from God by sin, living without the relationship with Him for which we were made. Paul describes people in this state as “having no hope, and without God in the world” (Ephesians 2:12). Lostness does not always look dramatic. It can wear a suit and sit in an office. It can hold a title in the community. It can even attend church faithfully while the heart remains far away, as Jesus said of some religious people of His day: “This people draweth nigh unto me with their mouth, and honoureth me with their lips; but their heart is far from me” (Matthew 15:8).

Rick Warren, whose PEACE Plan the leaflet discusses later, described this first giant as *spiritual emptiness*. The two ideas belong together. A lost person often feels empty: busy, perhaps successful, yet without lasting peace, purpose or hope. Many try to fill that emptiness with money, pleasure, power, or religious activity that has no living faith in it. Jesus asked, “For what shall it profit a man, if he shall gain the whole world, and lose his own soul?” (Mark 8:36).

Why this giant is listed first

The leaflet places spiritual lostness at the head of the list, and there is wisdom in that order. The other four giants are often fed by this one. A leader who does not fear God is more easily tempted to steal from the people. A community that has lost its moral anchor may tolerate the cheating and exploitation that deepen poverty. Neglect of health and of learning can grow where people have no sense that their lives belong to God. This does not mean that every poor or sick person is spiritually lost – that would be false

and unkind – but it does mean that lasting change in a nation must include changed hearts.

Zacchaeus shows this clearly. Once salvation came to his house, his relationship with money changed at once. He gave half of his goods to the poor and promised to restore fourfold anything he had taken by false accusation. He went far beyond what the Law required, which was to restore what had been taken and add a fifth part more (Leviticus 6:5). A changed heart produced changed dealings with his neighbours. When the first giant falls in a person's life, the others begin to shake.

God's answer to lostness

For God so loved the world, that he gave his only begotten Son, that whosoever believeth in him should not perish, but have everlasting life.

John 3:16 (KJV)

The good news is that God did not leave the lost to find their own way back. He came looking. Jesus called Himself the good shepherd (John 10:11), and He told of a shepherd who leaves the ninety and nine in the wilderness to go after the one sheep that is lost until he finds it (Luke 15:4-7). Salvation is a gift received by grace through faith, not a reward earned by good works (Ephesians 2:8-9). The church exists to carry this message to every person and every place.

Responding in Nigeria today

Nigeria has many churches, and in some cities there seems to be one on every street. Yet the leaflet's later call to plant churches "among the less-churched" reminds us that there are still villages, farm settlements, riverine communities, new estates, campuses and city neighbourhoods where the gospel is rarely heard in a way people understand. Even in areas full of churches, many people have never truly met Christ. Some attend a service only at Christmas or for a wedding. Some grew up in Christian homes but have drifted away. Spiritual lostness is close to all of us: in our families, compounds, markets and offices.

The response to this giant has three parts. First, *evangelism* – telling people the good news of Jesus plainly and lovingly, by word and by life. Second, *discipleship* – helping those who believe to grow, learn the Word and live it, so that they do not remain spiritual babies. Third, *church planting among the less-churched* – establishing living fellowships where there are none, so that new believers have a spiritual family to belong to and a place where they are taught.

Practical steps

- Write down the names of three people close to you who do not yet know Christ, and pray for them by name each day.
- Look for a natural opportunity this week to share what Jesus has done for you, without arguing or pressuring.

- Invite a friend or neighbour to a Bible study, a church programme, or simply to your home for a meal and conversation.
- If you are young in the faith, ask a mature Christian to read the Bible with you regularly; if you are mature, offer to do this for someone else.
- Ask your church leaders whether there is a nearby community with little or no gospel witness, and how you can help reach it.

Questions for reflection

1. Zacchaeus was rich and well known, yet lost. What does this teach you about who needs the gospel?
2. In what ways can a person be religious and still spiritually empty?
3. How has the gospel changed the way you use money, time or influence, as it changed Zacchaeus?
4. Who are the less-churched people in your own town or city, and what keeps them from hearing the gospel?

The Son of man came to seek and to save the lost – and He sends His church to do the same.

Giant 2: Corrupt Leadership

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

2. Corrupt Leadership (Ego-Centric Leaders) – Matthew 15:14

Let them alone: they be blind leaders of the blind. And if the blind lead the blind, both shall fall into the ditch.

Matthew 15:14 (KJV)

The setting of Jesus' words

In Matthew 15 some scribes and Pharisees from Jerusalem came to Jesus with a complaint: His disciples did not wash their hands according to the tradition of the elders before eating bread (Matthew 15:1-2). Jesus answered by exposing a deeper problem. These religious leaders had used their traditions to set aside God's commandment. He gave the example of teaching that allowed a person to declare his goods "a gift" to God and so escape the duty of honouring and supporting his father and mother (Matthew 15:3-6). The leaders looked devout, but their teaching led people to neglect what God had plainly commanded.

When the disciples told Jesus that the Pharisees were offended by His words, He replied that "every plant, which my heavenly Father hath not planted, shall be rooted up" (Matthew 15:13), and then spoke

the words of verse 14. A blind leader is one who cannot see the way but still insists on walking in front. The tragedy is that he does not fall alone. Those who follow him end up in the same ditch.

What makes a leader ego-centric

The leaflet adds a helpful description in brackets: *ego-centric leaders*. An ego-centric leader has placed himself or herself at the centre. Position becomes a means of getting honour, money, comfort and control, instead of a trust to be used for the good of others. Rick Warren used a similar term, *egocentric leadership*, for this second giant. Corruption is the natural fruit of such leadership: when the self is at the centre, public money becomes private money, rules are bent for friends, and the weak are pushed aside.

Jesus described the leadership of the world around Him and then drew a sharp line for His followers.

But Jesus called them to him, and saith unto them, Ye know that they which are accounted to rule over the Gentiles exercise lordship over them; and their great ones exercise authority upon them. But so shall it not be among you: but whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister: And whosoever of you will be the chiefest, shall be servant of all. For even the Son of man came not to be ministered unto, but to minister, and to give his life a ransom for many.

Mark 10:42-45 (KJV)

Here is the heart of servant leadership. In God's kingdom, greatness is measured not by how many people serve you but by how many people you serve. Jesus did not only teach this; He lived it, washing His disciples' feet and finally giving His life on the cross. Paul applied the same principle to every believer:

Let nothing be done through strife or vainglory; but in lowliness of mind let each esteem other better than themselves. Look not every man on his own things, but every man also on the things of others. Let this mind be in you, which was also in Christ Jesus:

Philippians 2:3-5 (KJV)

An ego-centric leader asks, "What will I gain?" A servant leader asks, "What do the people need, and what does God require?" The difference between those two questions shapes the life of a whole community.

Why leadership matters so much

When the righteous are in authority, the people rejoice: but when the wicked beareth rule, the people mourn.

Proverbs 29:2 (KJV)

Leadership is like the source of a river: whatever flows from it reaches everyone downstream. When leaders are righteous, justice is done, resources reach those they were meant for, and people have hope. When leaders are wicked, even hard-working citizens suffer. This is why corrupt leadership strengthens the other giants. Money meant for clinics, schools, roads and water can be diverted, leaving disease,

ignorance and poverty to grow.

Leadership is not only in government

It is easy to point at those in high office and forget that leadership happens at every level. A father and mother lead a home. A pastor, elder, choir leader or youth president leads in the church. A head teacher leads a school, a manager leads an office, and a market leader, landlord, union officer or community head leads others in daily life. The same giant can live in any of these places. A husband who rules his home by fear, a church leader who treats the congregation as a source of income, an officer who will not move a file without a bribe, and a senior colleague who takes credit for others' work are all showing the spirit of ego-centric leadership on a smaller stage.

The Bible set clear standards long ago. Jethro advised Moses to choose “able men, such as fear God, men of truth, hating covetousness” (Exodus 18:21). Peter urged church elders to feed the flock “not for filthy lucre, but of a ready mind”, and not “as being lords over God’s heritage, but being ensamples to the flock” (1 Peter 5:2-3). These standards apply wherever God places us in authority, whether over a household or a nation.

How Christians can respond

The church must be careful here. The answer to corrupt leadership is not bitterness, insults or violence, and it is certainly not to join in the corruption because “everyone is doing it”. Scripture calls us to pray “for kings, and for all that are in authority” (1 Timothy 2:2), to speak the truth with courage and respect, to do our own work honestly, and to raise a new generation of leaders who fear God. The PEACE Plan discussed later speaks of equipping servant leaders, and that is the positive side of fighting this giant: corrupt leadership is most surely defeated by forming Christlike leaders.

Practical steps

- Examine your own areas of leadership – home, church, work or community – and ask whether you lead to serve or to be served.
- Refuse to give or take bribes, even small ones, and look for honest ways to get things done.
- Pray regularly for those in authority in your local government, state and nation, asking God to give them wisdom and integrity.
- Where you have a say in choosing leaders or workers, look for proven character, not only for people who are close to you.
- Mentor a younger person: let them see how you handle money, correction and power.
- Be accountable: let trusted people check how funds and decisions are handled in any group you lead.

Questions for reflection

1. Why do you think Jesus said that both the blind leader and the blind follower fall into the ditch?
What responsibility do followers have?
2. What are the signs that a leader has become ego-centric?
3. In which area of life do you exercise leadership, and how could you serve better there?
4. How can the church raise leaders who will remain honest when they reach positions of power?

Whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister.

Giant 3: Poverty

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

3. Poverty – Proverbs 24:33-34; Proverbs 28:19. Ref: Proverbs 20:13; 21:17; 23:21; 28:19

The third giant is one that many readers know from personal experience. Poverty is more than a shortage of money. It means struggling to feed a family, pay school fees, keep a roof overhead or afford treatment when someone falls sick. It often brings shame, fear and hopelessness. The leaflet points us to the book of Proverbs, which speaks often and practically about how want comes and how plenty is gained.

The field of the slothful

Yet a little sleep, a little slumber, a little folding of the hands to sleep: So shall thy poverty come as one that travelleth; and thy want as an armed man.

Proverbs 24:33-34 (KJV)

These verses close a short story. The writer passed by the field of the slothful and saw it grown over with thorns and nettles, with its stone wall broken down. He considered it well and received instruction (Proverbs 24:30-32). Notice that the sluggard never decides to become poor. He simply chooses “a little sleep, a little slumber”. Each delay seems harmless, but together they add up. Poverty then comes “as one that travelleth” – steadily, like a traveller drawing nearer on the road – and “as an armed man” – with a force that cannot easily be resisted. The lesson is that small daily habits have large results.

Tilling your own land

He that tilleth his land shall have plenty of bread: but he that followeth after vain persons shall have poverty enough.

Proverbs 28:19 (KJV)

This proverb sets two paths side by side. One person tills his land – he gives patient, steady effort to the work in front of him. The other follows after “vain persons”, that is, empty and worthless people or

pursuits: idlers, schemers and those with big talk and no substance. The first has plenty of bread; the second has “poverty enough”. In our day the vain pursuit might be a money-doubling scheme, endless betting, or friends who promise quick wealth without honest work. The proverb urges us to value the “land” God has given – our skills, trade, farm, shop or job – and to work it faithfully.

The leaflet’s further references

The leaflet lists three more proverbs for further study. Each names a habit that leads towards want.

Love not sleep, lest thou come to poverty; open thine eyes, and thou shalt be satisfied with bread.

Proverbs 20:13 (KJV)

Love of sleep. Rest is a gift from God, but loving sleep means preferring comfort to responsibility. The remedy is to “open thine eyes” – to be alert, rise to the work and notice the opportunities God places around you.

He that loveth pleasure shall be a poor man: he that loveth wine and oil shall not be rich.

Proverbs 21:17 (KJV)

Love of pleasure. Wine and oil were signs of feasting and luxury. The person who spends everything on enjoyment today, living above his income, will have nothing for tomorrow. In our setting this can mean parties far beyond one’s means, costly phones and clothes bought on debt, or spending simply to impress others.

For the drunkard and the glutton shall come to poverty: and drowsiness shall clothe a man with rags.

Proverbs 23:21 (KJV)

Lack of self-control. Drunkenness and gluttony waste money and damage health, and the drowsiness that follows leads to neglected work. Together they “clothe a man with rags”. Proverbs 28:19 appears twice in the leaflet’s references, and it is a fitting reminder that diligent work on one’s own land is the positive answer to all these habits.

An honest and balanced view

It would be a serious mistake to read these proverbs and conclude that every poor person is lazy or wasteful. Proverbs speaks of personal habits, but the same book, and the whole Bible, also names other causes of poverty. Many hard-working people remain poor because of injustice, oppression, sickness, disaster, conflict, or systems that deny them a fair reward for their labour.

Much food is in the tillage of the poor: but there is that is destroyed for want of judgment.

Proverbs 13:23 (KJV)

In other words, the poor man’s field could produce much food, but it is swept away where justice is lacking. God takes this very seriously:

Rob not the poor, because he is poor: neither oppress the afflicted in the gate: For the LORD will plead their cause, and spoil the soul of those that spoiled them.

Proverbs 22:22-23 (KJV)

So the Christian response to poverty has two sides. We must encourage diligence, self-control and wise habits, beginning with ourselves. We must also refuse to despise the poor, speak up against their oppression, and show them practical kindness. Scripture puts this strongly: “He that hath pity upon the poor lendeth unto the LORD; and that which he hath given will he pay him again” (Proverbs 19:17). When James, Cephas and John, the leaders of the church in Jerusalem, gave Paul and Barnabas “the right hands of fellowship” and agreed that they should go to the Gentiles, they asked only “that we should remember the poor”, and Paul added, “the same which I also was forward to do” – that is, the very thing he was eager to do (Galatians 2:9-10).

Personal responses

At a personal level, fighting poverty begins with honest work and good stewardship. Paul wrote, “Let him that stole steal no more: but rather let him labour, working with his hands the thing which is good, that he may have to give to him that needeth” (Ephesians 4:28). Notice the goal: we work not only to survive but to be able to give. Learning a skill or trade, taking your job seriously, keeping records in your business, spending less than you earn and saving something regularly, however small, are all ways of tilling your land. “Wealth gotten by vanity shall be diminished: but he that gathereth by labour shall increase” (Proverbs 13:11).

Community responses

Poverty is also fought together. Many Nigerian communities already have traditions of mutual help, such as thrift contributions and rotating savings groups (known in many Yoruba communities as *ajo* or *esusu*), cooperative societies, and trade or community associations. Churches can build on these: running skills training for young people, helping members form well-managed cooperatives, teaching basic money management, and supporting widows, orphans and the elderly.

Care must be taken to help in ways that build dignity and ability rather than dependency. Giving food to a hungry family is right and urgent, and James warns against sending the needy away with kind words only (James 2:15-16). But where possible the church should also help those who are able to work to find employment, learn skills or start small businesses, so that tomorrow they too can give. Help should never come with humiliation; the poor are brothers and sisters, not objects of pity.

Practical steps

- Keep a simple record of your income and spending for one month, and see where money is being wasted.

- Set aside a fixed portion of every income for savings, even if it is small.
- Refuse any scheme that promises to double your money quickly, and seek advice from wise, experienced people before investing.
- Learn one new skill this year that can increase your usefulness or your income.
- Join or form a trustworthy savings group or cooperative with clear records and honest leaders.
- Identify one family or individual you can help in a way that respects their dignity and builds their ability.

Questions for reflection

1. Which of the habits named in Proverbs 20:13, 21:17, 23:21 and 24:33-34 do you most need to guard against?
2. Why is it wrong to assume that every poor person is lazy? What do Proverbs 13:23 and 22:22-23 add to the picture?
3. What “vain persons” or empty pursuits tempt people in your community away from honest work?
4. How can your church help the poor without creating dependency or causing shame?

Tilling your land and remembering the poor belong together.

Giant 4: Disease

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

4. Disease – Matthew 4:23

And Jesus went about all Galilee, teaching in their synagogues, and preaching the gospel of the kingdom, and healing all manner of sickness and all manner of disease among the people.

Matthew 4:23 (KJV)

Teaching, preaching and healing

This verse summarises Jesus’ ministry in Galilee, and Matthew repeats almost the same words later (Matthew 9:35). Three actions stand side by side: *teaching* in the synagogues, *preaching* the gospel of the kingdom, and *healing* all manner of sickness and disease. Jesus did not separate care for the soul from care for the body. He instructed minds, called hearts to repentance and faith, and relieved suffering bodies – all as part of one ministry. Peter later summed up His life by saying that He “went about doing good, and healing all that were oppressed of the devil; for God was with him” (Acts 10:38).

The healings of Jesus were signs that the kingdom of God had drawn near. They showed God's compassion and His power over sickness, and they point forward to the day when "there shall be no more death, neither sorrow, nor crying, neither shall there be any more pain" (Revelation 21:4). Until that day, disease remains one of the great enemies of human life. It takes children before their time, weakens workers, empties savings and leaves families grieving.

God cares about your health

Beloved, I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth.

3 John 2 (KJV)

John's greeting to his friend Gaius shows that it is right for Christians to desire and pray for good health. The body is not worthless or something to be ignored; Paul calls it "the temple of the Holy Ghost" (1 Corinthians 6:19). Caring for your own body, and for the bodies of others, honours the God who made them.

At the same time, the Bible is honest that faithful people sometimes fall sick. Paul wrote that he had left his fellow worker Trophimus "at Miletum sick" (2 Timothy 4:20), and he advised Timothy to take a little wine "for thy stomach's sake and thine often infirmities" (1 Timothy 5:23). Sickness is not in itself proof of sin or weak faith – of the man born blind Jesus said, "Neither hath this man sinned, nor his parents" (John 9:3) – and the sick must never be blamed or shamed. They need our prayers, our presence and our practical help.

Faith and medicine are not enemies

Some believers think that seeing a doctor or taking medicine shows a lack of faith. The Bible does not teach this. Luke, whom the church has long recognised as the writer of the Gospel that bears his name and of the book of Acts, was a physician, and Paul spoke of him warmly:

Luke, the beloved physician, and Demas, greet you.

Colossians 4:14 (KJV)

Paul could call Luke "the beloved physician" without any hint of disapproval, and Luke remained a faithful companion in Paul's ministry (2 Timothy 4:11); nothing in Scripture suggests that following Christ required him to give up his calling. In the Old Testament, when King Hezekiah was sick unto death, God heard his prayer and promised healing, and the prophet Isaiah also gave instruction for a lump of figs to be laid as a plaster upon the boil (Isaiah 38:1-5, 21). Prayer and treatment went together. In Jesus' parable the good Samaritan "bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine" (Luke 10:34), using the remedies of his day. God heals in many ways: sometimes directly and miraculously, and often through the knowledge, skill and medicines He has allowed human beings to discover. We should pray for the sick and trust God fully, and we should also use the good means He provides.

For this reason no one should ever be told to stop prescribed treatment in order to prove their faith. A person who believes God has healed them should continue to follow the advice of qualified health workers and allow proper tests to confirm what God has done. Thanksgiving and good medical care are not in competition.

The legacy of mission hospitals

The link between the gospel and healing has deep roots in Nigeria. Christian missions founded many hospitals, clinics and schools across the country. Well-known examples include Wesley Guild Hospital in Ilesa, which has Methodist roots, and the Baptist Medical Centre in Ogbomoso. Missionaries and Nigerian believers alike understood that loving people in the name of Jesus meant caring for their bodies as well as their souls, and generations of patients have been treated in such places. This heritage reminds the church that healthcare is not a distraction from the gospel but part of its witness.

Prevention: fighting the giant before it strikes

Much disease can be prevented, and prevention is often cheaper and kinder than cure. The points below are general health education, not medical advice for any individual. Always seek the guidance of a qualified doctor, nurse or community health worker about your own health, and never abandon treatment you have been given without speaking to them.

- **Clean water and sanitation.** Drink water from a safe source, or water that has been boiled or properly treated, and keep toilets and surroundings clean. Many illnesses, including those that cause diarrhoea, spread through unsafe water and poor sanitation.
- **Hand-washing.** Washing hands with soap and clean water, especially after using the toilet, before eating and before preparing food, is a simple habit that helps prevent the spread of many infections.
- **Protection from malaria.** Malaria remains a major health concern in Nigeria. Sleeping under an insecticide-treated mosquito net, clearing stagnant water where mosquitoes breed, and seeking prompt testing and proper treatment when fever comes are important steps.
- **Vaccination.** Follow the immunisation schedule recommended by health workers for children, and ask about any vaccines advised for adults.
- **Regular check-ups.** High blood pressure is a significant health concern in Nigeria and often gives no warning signs until harm has been done. Diabetes can also go unnoticed for a long time. Having your blood pressure and blood sugar checked regularly, especially as you grow older, allows problems to be found and treated early.
- **Wise use of medicines.** Take medicines as directed by qualified health workers, and be careful about buying strong drugs without proper advice.

The church's role

Churches can fight this giant in many practical ways: praying for the sick and visiting them; hosting health talks led by qualified professionals; arranging blood pressure checks after services; encouraging young members to train as doctors, nurses, pharmacists, laboratory scientists and community health workers; supporting mission clinics; and helping poor members pay for treatment. Christian health workers can see their work as a calling from God and do it with honesty, compassion and excellence.

Practical steps

- Pray by name for the sick in your family and church, and visit or call at least one of them this week.
- If you have not had your blood pressure checked in the past year, arrange to have it done by a qualified health worker.
- Check your home for stagnant water, torn mosquito nets or unsafe drinking water, and fix what you can.
- Encourage anyone who has stopped treatment for religious reasons to speak again with their doctor and their pastor.
- Ask your church whether it can host a health awareness day with qualified health professionals.

Questions for reflection

1. What does Matthew 4:23 teach about the relationship between preaching, teaching and healing?
2. Why do some believers feel that using medicine shows weak faith, and how would you answer them from Scripture?
3. Which preventable illnesses affect your community most, and what simple steps could reduce them?
4. How can your church show Christ's compassion to people living with long-term illness?

Pray in faith, use the means God provides, and never abandon good treatment.

Giant 5: Ignorance

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

5. Ignorance – 2 Corinthians 2:11; Daniel 12:4

The leaflet's opening words declared that "the time of ignorance has passed". It is fitting, then, that ignorance is named as the fifth giant. Ignorance means not knowing what we need to know. It is not the same as lack of intelligence; many clever people are ignorant of important things. Nor is it only the inability to read and write, though illiteracy is a serious part of it, and Rick Warren named illiteracy among his global giants. Ignorance is dangerous because we cannot guard against a threat we do not see,

or seize an opportunity we do not recognise.

Not ignorant of Satan's devices

Lest Satan should get an advantage of us: for we are not ignorant of his devices.

2 Corinthians 2:11 (KJV)

To understand this verse we must read what comes before it. In 2 Corinthians 2:5-10 Paul writes about a member of the church in Corinth who had caused grief and had been disciplined by the congregation. That discipline had done its work, and the man was now deeply sorrowful. Paul therefore urges the church to change its approach:

Sufficient to such a man is this punishment, which was inflicted of many. So that contrariwise ye ought rather to forgive him, and comfort him, lest perhaps such a one should be swallowed up with overmuch sorrow. Wherefore I beseech you that ye would confirm your love toward him.

2 Corinthians 2:6-8 (KJV)

Paul adds that he too forgives, “lest Satan should get an advantage of us”. The danger was real. A church that refused to forgive a repentant brother could crush him with despair, and could itself become harsh, proud and divided. Satan could use either result. So one of the devices Paul has in mind is unforgiveness – turning godly discipline into endless punishment, and allowing bitterness and division to take root in the fellowship.

A device is a scheme or a method. Scripture exposes several of Satan's schemes: lying and deception, for Jesus called him “a liar, and the father of it” (John 8:44); questioning God's Word, as the serpent did in Eden with the words “Yea, hath God said...?” (Genesis 3:1); accusation, for he is called “the accuser of our brethren” (Revelation 12:10); and the stirring up of anger that is allowed to linger, for Paul warns, “let not the sun go down upon your wrath: Neither give place to the devil” (Ephesians 4:26-27). A believer who does not know these schemes can be defeated without even realising that a battle is going on. A church that understands them can forgive quickly, keep unity, test what it hears and stand firm.

Knowledge shall be increased

But thou, O Daniel, shut up the words, and seal the book, even to the time of the end: many shall run to and fro, and knowledge shall be increased.

Daniel 12:4 (KJV)

These words were spoken to Daniel at the close of his visions concerning the time of the end. Bible teachers have understood “knowledge shall be increased” in different ways. Many take it to mean that understanding of God's prophetic word would grow as the end drew nearer; others also see in it a picture of the great increase in travel and learning in later ages. The leaflet uses the verse to remind us that we are living in a time of knowledge. Whatever the full meaning of the prophecy, it is plain that knowledge is now more widely available than ever before. Books, schools, radio, the internet and mobile phones

place information within reach of ordinary people in towns and villages. The question is whether God's people will use this opportunity wisely or remain ignorant in an age of knowledge.

Destroyed for lack of knowledge

My people are destroyed for lack of knowledge: because thou hast rejected knowledge, I will also reject thee, that thou shalt be no priest to me: seeing thou hast forgotten the law of thy God, I will also forget thy children.

Hosea 4:6 (KJV)

Hosea spoke to Israel in a time of deep moral decline. The people's problem was not that knowledge was unavailable, but that it had been rejected and God's law forgotten, and the priests who should have taught them had failed in their duty. The result was destruction, reaching even to their children. This is a sober warning: ignorance that comes from neglecting what God has made available is not innocent. By contrast, Proverbs urges us to pursue understanding with all our strength:

Wisdom is the principal thing; therefore get wisdom: and with all thy getting get understanding.

Proverbs 4:7 (KJV)

Four areas where ignorance does harm

Ignorance of God's Word. Many Christians attend church for years but have never read the Bible through for themselves. They are easily carried away by false teaching, fear and superstition. The believers in Berea were commended because they "searched the scriptures daily, whether those things were so" (Acts 17:11), testing even what the apostle Paul taught them.

Ignorance about health. People may suffer greatly from conditions that could have been prevented or treated early, simply because they did not know the warning signs, trusted harmful rumours, or delayed seeking help. Messages forwarded from phone to phone can spread false cures as quickly as true advice. Scripture commends the person who thinks ahead: "A prudent man foreseeth the evil, and hideth himself; but the simple pass on, and are punished" (Proverbs 22:3). Learning the basics of health from qualified people, and checking what we hear before believing it, is part of that prudence.

Ignorance about money. Without basic knowledge of budgeting, saving, debt and fraud, hard-earned income slips away, and people fall easy prey to schemes that promise quick wealth. "The simple believeth every word: but the prudent man looketh well to his going" (Proverbs 14:15). Before handing money to any scheme, a wise person asks who is behind it, how the money is really made, and what happens if it fails – and seeks counsel from people with genuine experience.

Ignorance of rights and duties. People who do not know their lawful rights can be cheated and exploited, and those who do not know their responsibilities may fail their families, communities and nation. Paul taught believers to "render therefore to all their dues" (Romans 13:7), which requires knowing what those dues are.

The church as a place of learning

From the beginning the church has been a teaching community. The first believers “continued stedfastly in the apostles’ doctrine” (Acts 2:42), and Christ gave pastors and teachers to equip His people “for the work of the ministry” (Ephesians 4:11-12). Christian missions founded many schools in Nigeria, and churches continue to run schools and Bible colleges today. A local church can fight ignorance through Sunday school for all ages, Bible study groups, reading classes for adults who never had the chance to learn, support for children’s schooling, and practical seminars on health, marriage, work and money led by people with genuine knowledge.

Practical steps

- Make a plan to read through one Gospel, and then the whole New Testament, keeping a notebook for questions.
- If there is someone you have refused to forgive even though they have repented, take a step towards reconciliation this week.
- Choose reliable sources for health and financial information, and check rumours before you pass them on.
- Offer to teach someone to read, or support a child’s education with books or fees.
- Suggest to your church or fellowship one practical subject on which members need teaching.

Questions for reflection

1. According to 2 Corinthians 2:5-11, how could unforgiveness give Satan an advantage in a church?
2. Hosea 4:6 says God’s people were destroyed because they rejected knowledge. What knowledge are Christians around you neglecting?
3. In which of the four areas – God’s Word, health, money, or rights and duties – do you most need to grow?
4. How can your church become a stronger place of learning for children, youth and adults?

We are not ignorant of his devices – so let us learn, forgive and stand firm.

Combating the Giants: The PEACE Plan

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

HOW DO WE VICTORIOUSLY COMBAT THESE GIANTS?

Solution: A discovery of the PEACE MISSION was made by Rick Warren (USA), who strategically drew the following action plans by defining each letter of PEACE:

P – PLANTING CHURCHES among the less-churched

E – ERADICATE corrupt leaders or ego-centric leaders

A – ASSIST the poor

C – CURE DISEASES

E – EDUCATE the next generation

Having named the five giants, the leaflet asks the most important question: how can they be defeated? It is not enough to describe problems or complain about them. God's people are called to act, and the leaflet's word "victoriously" reminds us that we do not fight as people expecting defeat. As David told Goliath, "the battle is the LORD's" (1 Samuel 17:47).

Who is Rick Warren?

Rick Warren is an American pastor who founded Saddleback Church in California and wrote the widely read book *The Purpose Driven Life*. In the early-to-mid 2000s he and Saddleback Church introduced what they called the PEACE Plan. Its aim was to mobilise ordinary local churches to take action against what Warren called global giants: spiritual emptiness, egocentric or self-serving leadership, extreme poverty, pandemic disease, and illiteracy or ignorance. The leaflet's five giants closely follow this list.

The leaflet speaks of this as a "discovery". We should understand that word humbly. The needs themselves were not new, and the church has worked against them in many lands and many generations. What the PEACE Plan offered was a memorable way of gathering the church's long-standing tasks into one simple plan, matching each giant with an action that ordinary Christians can take.

A note on the wording of the letters

Readers who look up the PEACE Plan elsewhere will notice some differences of wording. Saddleback's own description of the letters has been: *Plant churches* (later also described as *Promote reconciliation*), *Equip servant leaders*, *Assist the poor*, *Care for the sick*, and *Educate the next generation*. The leaflet expresses the second letter as "Eradicate corrupt leaders or ego-centric leaders" and the fourth as "Cure diseases".

These are best understood as different emphases rather than contradictions. The leaflet's "Eradicate corrupt leaders" names the giant that equipping servant leaders is meant to defeat. As Giant 2 explained, Christians defeat bad leadership not by hatred or force but by forming leaders of a different spirit –

servants who fear God. In the same way, “Cure diseases” and “Care for the sick” belong together: we work for cure wherever it is possible, and we care for the sick always, including those whose illness cannot be cured.

The plan matched to the giants

- Spiritual lostness is met by **P** – planting churches among the less-churched.
- Corrupt, ego-centric leadership is met by **E** – eradicating it by equipping servant leaders.
- Poverty is met by **A** – assisting the poor.
- Disease is met by **C** – curing diseases and caring for the sick.
- Ignorance is met by **E** – educating the next generation.

Why local churches matter

One of the most important ideas behind the PEACE Plan is that these giants will not be defeated only by governments, large charities or international organisations, valuable as their work can be. The local church is present in places those bodies may never reach: in villages without a hospital, in city neighbourhoods without a good school, among families who would never walk into an office to ask for help. Every congregation has people with skills, time, homes, prayers and resources. When ordinary believers in many ordinary churches each do their part, the combined effect is far greater than any single organisation could achieve.

This means the PEACE Plan is not a project for someone else. A small fellowship meeting in a rented shop can start a Bible study in a nearby village. A youth group can run a reading class. A women’s fellowship can help a widow restart her trade. A church with a nurse among its members can organise a health talk. Jesus compared the kingdom of heaven to a grain of mustard seed, “the least of all seeds”, which grows until it becomes a tree (Matthew 13:31-32). We must not despise small beginnings.

From whom the whole body fitly joined together and compacted by that which every joint supplieth, according to the effectual working in the measure of every part, maketh increase of the body unto the edifying of itself in love.

Ephesians 4:16 (KJV)

Paul pictures the church as a body in which every joint supplies something. No single member does everything, but when each part works, the whole body grows. This is the principle behind a plan that depends on ordinary congregations: the giants are faced not by a few heroes but by a body in which every member does its share.

Practical steps

- Walk or drive through your neighbourhood with the five giants in mind, and write down where you see each one most clearly.
- Find out what other churches and Christian groups near you are already doing against these giants, so that you can support good work rather than compete with it.
- Read Numbers 13:25-33 and 1 Samuel 17:32-37 side by side, and note the difference between a report shaped by fear and a response shaped by faith.
- Ask your pastor or fellowship leader which one of the five areas your congregation could take up first.

Questions for reflection

1. Why is it important that the leaflet speaks of combating the giants “victoriously”?
2. How does equipping servant leaders help to eradicate corrupt leadership?
3. What can your local church do that large organisations cannot?
4. Which of the five giants do you think your own congregation is best placed to face, and why?

Every local church, however small, has a part to play against the giants.

The Five Letters of PEACE Explained

In this section each letter of the PEACE Plan is taken in turn, with key Scripture and suggestions for how it can be lived out in a Nigerian setting. The headings follow the leaflet’s wording, with Saddleback’s wording joined to it where that helps to explain the letter.

P – Planting churches among the less-churched

But ye shall receive power, after that the Holy Ghost is come upon you: and ye shall be witnesses unto me both in Jerusalem, and in all Judaea, and in Samaria, and unto the uttermost part of the earth.

Acts 1:8 (KJV)

Go ye therefore, and teach all nations, baptizing them in the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Ghost: Teaching them to observe all things whatsoever I have commanded you: and, lo, I am with you alway, even unto the end of the world. Amen.

Matthew 28:19-20 (KJV)

Jesus’ plan for reaching the world began in Jerusalem and spread outwards to Judaea, Samaria and the uttermost part of the earth. In the book of Acts we see the result: wherever the apostles preached, believers were gathered into churches, and these churches in turn became bases for further witness. The

Great Commission is not only to make converts but to teach disciples – people who are baptised, instructed in all that Jesus commanded, and brought into a community where they can grow.

The leaflet specifies “among the less-churched”. Giant 1 has already described the kinds of places where gospel witness is weak; here the question is how a church actually goes there. The aim is not to open a new church beside several others in order to compete, but to strengthen the witness where it is thin. Paul described his own practice in these words: “so have I strived to preach the gospel, not where Christ was named, lest I should build upon another man’s foundation” (Romans 15:20). A sending church can begin by praying together about one community, sending a small team regularly rather than once, listening to the people’s needs, and teaching in a language they understand well, since the gospel speaks most clearly in the language of the heart.

Church planting does not always start with a building. It can begin with a Bible study in a home, a Sunday afternoon fellowship in a compound, or a few families meeting in a classroom. What matters most is faithful teaching of the Word, prayer, love, and leaders who can be trusted.

E – Eradicating corrupt leadership by equipping servant leaders

And the things that thou hast heard of me among many witnesses, the same commit thou to faithful men, who shall be able to teach others also.

2 Timothy 2:2 (KJV)

Paul’s instruction to Timothy describes four generations of leaders: Paul, Timothy, faithful men, and the others whom they would teach. This is how servant leadership multiplies. Leaders are not only chosen; they are formed over time through teaching, example and correction. Paul looked first for people who were “faithful” – trustworthy in character – before they were given the responsibility to teach.

In a Nigerian church this can look like a pastor meeting regularly with a few younger leaders; youth and student fellowships training members to handle money openly and lead meetings fairly; Christian professionals mentoring young graduates in integrity at work; and churches teaching that public service is a place to serve God and neighbour, not a chance to enrich oneself. Families also form leaders: children who see their parents keep promises, admit mistakes and treat house helps with respect learn what godly authority looks like.

A – Assisting the poor

If a brother or sister be naked, and destitute of daily food, And one of you say unto them, Depart in peace, be ye warmed and filled; notwithstanding ye give them not those things which are needful to the body; what doth it profit?

James 2:15-16 (KJV)

James will not allow faith to remain words only. Kind wishes do not fill an empty stomach or clothe a shivering child. Assisting the poor is part of real, living faith, and, as Giant 3 noted from Proverbs 19:17,

God Himself counts what we give to the poor as a loan made to Him.

Giant 3 described many ways of helping. Here the concern is how a church does it faithfully. When the widows of the Greek-speaking believers in Jerusalem were being neglected in the daily ministration, the apostles asked the church to choose seven men “of honest report, full of the Holy Ghost and wisdom” to oversee that work, so that the care would be fair and no group would be left out (Acts 6:1-3). In the same way, a church welfare committee should be made up of trusted people, keep written records of what is received and given, report the accounts openly to the congregation, and keep the names and circumstances of those helped in confidence. Needs are best met through members who know the family personally, so that help reaches the right people and is given with love rather than suspicion. Paul also taught that giving should be willing and in proportion to what each person has (2 Corinthians 8:12): “Every man according as he purposeth in his heart, so let him give; not grudgingly, or of necessity: for God loveth a cheerful giver” (2 Corinthians 9:7).

C – Curing diseases and caring for the sick

And as ye go, preach, saying, The kingdom of heaven is at hand. Heal the sick, raise the dead, cleanse the lepers, cast out devils: freely ye have received, freely give.

Matthew 10:7-8 (KJV)

And went to him, and bound up his wounds, pouring in oil and wine, and set him on his own beast, and brought him to an inn, and took care of him.

Luke 10:34 (KJV)

When Jesus sent out the twelve, He told them to preach and to heal, and He added, “freely ye have received, freely give.” The good Samaritan shows what caring for the sick looks like in ordinary life. He stopped, drew near, treated the wounds with what he had, brought the man to a place of care, and paid for his keeping (Luke 10:35). He did not first ask where the wounded man came from.

Before sending them, Jesus had given the twelve power “to heal all manner of sickness and all manner of disease” (Matthew 10:1). For Christian health workers today, “freely ye have received, freely give” does not mean that clinics must never charge fees; buildings, staff and medicines must be paid for. It does mean that the love of money must never rule a place of healing. A Christian clinic should be known for honest charges, for not turning away a patient in an emergency because money is not yet at hand, for telling patients the truth about their condition, and for treating the poor with the same respect as the rich. Giant 4 has already listed ways a congregation can support the sick; here the challenge is for every believer who works in health – in a government hospital, a private clinic, a laboratory or a pharmacy – to see that daily work as part of Christ’s own ministry of healing.

E – Educating the next generation

Train up a child in the way he should go: and when he is old, he will not depart from it.

And that from a child thou hast known the holy scriptures, which are able to make thee wise unto salvation through faith which is in Christ Jesus.

Timothy knew the Scriptures “from a child”. Paul mentions the sincere faith that dwelt first in Timothy’s grandmother Lois and his mother Eunice (2 Timothy 1:5), and it is clear that this faith was passed on to him. Education begins at home, where parents and grandparents teach children to know God, to love learning, to work hard and to live honestly. The church continues it through Sunday school, children’s and youth ministry, and in many places through Christian schools.

Educating the next generation includes both the knowledge of God and the knowledge of the world He made. Building on the heritage of mission schools already mentioned, churches can serve today by helping with school fees for children who might otherwise drop out, running holiday lessons and reading clubs, providing books, encouraging girls as well as boys to complete their education, and teaching young people to think clearly and live wisely. A child who is taught well is better prepared to resist the giants of lostness, corruption, poverty, disease and ignorance.

Practical steps

- Choose one letter of PEACE where you can serve this month, and tell someone in your church what you plan to do.
- Find out whether your church is already active in each of the five areas; where it is not, pray and talk with your leaders about one small activity to begin.
- Identify one skill, profession or resource you have that could strengthen one of the five actions.
- Pray through the five letters once a week, naming people and places you want God to reach.

Discuss together

1. In which letter of PEACE is your church strongest, and in which is it weakest?
2. Why do you think Jesus joined preaching with healing when He sent out His disciples?
3. What would it look like for your family to take Proverbs 22:6 seriously this year?
4. How can the five actions support one another rather than operate separately?

Plant, equip, assist, care and educate – five actions against five giants.

Our Concern: Churches, Clinics and Education

FROM THE ORIGINAL LEAFLET

OUR CONCERN IN THE PEACE MISSION:

P – PLANTING CHURCHES

C – CURING DISEASES (medical)

E – EDUCATION

After setting out the whole PEACE Plan, the leaflet ends by naming the part this ministry has taken as its own particular concern: planting churches, curing diseases, and education. This does not mean that assisting the poor or raising servant leaders is unimportant. It reflects a principle found throughout Scripture: God gives different gifts to different members of the body, and each should serve faithfully in the calling given to them (Romans 12:4-8; 1 Corinthians 12:4-7).

As every man hath received the gift, even so minister the same one to another, as good stewards of the manifold grace of God.

1 Peter 4:10 (KJV)

Peter describes every believer as a steward of a gift received from God. A ministry, like a person, is wise to give its strength to the gifts and calling God has entrusted to it, while honouring those who serve Him in other ways.

Why these three?

Practical Love Publications was founded by Rev. Dr. Moses Remi Owoeye, who is both a medical doctor and a minister of the gospel. It is natural that a ministry shaped by that double calling should give special attention to the places where preaching and healing meet. The word “(medical)” in the leaflet makes clear that curing diseases is meant practically, through medical care, and not only through prayer – though prayer always belongs with it. Education is joined to both, because churches need well-taught believers and trained leaders, and good health depends on people who understand how to care for their bodies and when to seek help.

These three also echo the pattern of Jesus’ own ministry in Matthew 4:23: *preaching* the gospel of the kingdom, which gathers believers into churches; *healing* all manner of sickness, which today includes medical care; and *teaching*, which is the heart of education. Seen this way, the ministry’s chosen concern mirrors what Jesus did as He went about all Galilee.

And he sent them to preach the kingdom of God, and to heal the sick.

Luke 9:2 (KJV)

When Jesus sent out the twelve, preaching and healing were given to them as one commission. A ministry that joins churches and clinics is not inventing a new idea; it is taking up, in a modern form, the pattern Jesus gave to His first disciples.

Churches with clinics

The ministry's letter *A Vision for Churches and Clinics*, also found on the Practical Love Publications page, describes this concern in more detail: planting churches with medical clinics attached. In such a model a congregation does more than hold services. It becomes a centre where the gospel is preached, the sick receive care, and people are taught – a visible sign of God's love in the community. Readers who want to understand the ministry's vision more fully are encouraged to read that letter alongside this study.

This vision takes seriously the needs of communities where both the gospel and good healthcare are hard to reach. A clinic can open doors of trust, and a church can give a clinic a caring, prayerful and honest foundation. Yet the clinic is not merely a tool for evangelism. Caring for the sick is itself obedience to Christ, whether or not a patient ever joins the church, and every patient should be treated with the same compassion and respect.

How you can take part

The ministry's concern need not remain the concern of a few. Every reader can find a place in it.

- **Pray.** Pray for new churches to be planted among the less-churched, for health workers and clinics, for teachers and students, and for the leaders of this ministry.
- **Give.** Support church planting, clinic and education work through your local church or trustworthy ministries, and expect clear accounts of how gifts are used.
- **Volunteer your skills.** Doctors, nurses, pharmacists, laboratory staff, teachers, builders, accountants, drivers and administrators all have gifts that this kind of work needs.
- **Support a local clinic or school.** Visit, encourage, donate equipment or books, or help a patient or pupil who cannot afford fees.
- **Start a Bible study.** Planting a church often begins with a few people meeting to read God's Word. You can begin in your home, workplace or neighbourhood.
- **Share this study.** Use it with your family or fellowship, and pass it on to others who can teach it.

Questions for reflection

1. Why is it wise for a ministry to focus on particular parts of the PEACE Plan rather than trying to do everything?
2. How do planting churches, curing diseases and education strengthen one another?
3. What gift, skill or resource could you offer to this kind of work?

4. Is there a community near you that needs both a church and better healthcare? What first step could be taken?

Preaching, healing and teaching – the pattern of Jesus is the concern of this ministry.

Facing Your Giants

The five giants can seem overwhelming. Spiritual lostness, corrupt leadership, poverty, disease and ignorance are older than any of us, and they are found in every nation. It is easy to feel like the spies who saw themselves as grasshoppers. The story of David and Goliath gives a better picture to carry away from this study.

Five smooth stones

And he took his staff in his hand, and chose him five smooth stones out of the brook, and put them in a shepherd's bag which he had, even in a scrip; and his sling was in his hand: and he drew near to the Philistine.

1 Samuel 17:40 (KJV)

David did not go out in armour. King Saul armed him with a helmet of brass and a coat of mail, but David put them off again, saying, “I cannot go with these; for I have not proved them” (1 Samuel 17:38-39). Instead he used what God had already trained him to use as a shepherd: a staff, a sling and stones from the brook. The Bible does not tell us why he chose five stones, and we should not build teaching on the number. But as a picture for this study, those five stones remind us that God places simple, proven tools in the hands of His people. Against the five giants, the church has five actions: planting churches; equipping servant leaders; assisting the poor; curing diseases and caring for the sick; and educating the next generation.

Notice too that David chose *smooth* stones, shaped by the water of the brook over a long time. The tools God uses are often formed slowly, through years of faithful prayer, study, work and service that nobody else notices. David's hidden years of defending his father's sheep from the lion and the bear (1 Samuel 17:34-36) prepared him for the public day of battle. The faithfulness you show in small things today may be God's preparation for the giant you will face tomorrow.

The battle is the LORD's

Then said David to the Philistine, Thou comest to me with a sword, and with a spear, and with a shield: but I come to thee in the name of the LORD of hosts, the God of the armies of Israel, whom thou hast defied. This day will the LORD deliver thee into mine hand; and I will smite thee, and take thine head from thee; and I will give the carcasses of the host of the Philistines this day unto the fowls

of the air, and to the wild beasts of the earth; that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel. And all this assembly shall know that the LORD saveth not with sword and spear: for the battle is the LORD's: and he will give you into our hands.

1 Samuel 17:45-47 (KJV)

David's confidence was not in his sling but in the name of the LORD. His goal was not his own fame but "that all the earth may know that there is a God in Israel". This is the spirit in which Christians face the global giants. We do not plant churches to build our own empires, help the poor in order to be praised, run clinics for gain at the expense of the sick, or teach only to win status. We act so that people may know the living God, who seeks the lost, hates injustice, cares for the poor, heals the sick and gives wisdom to all who ask Him.

Remember also that David's victory stirred others to act. When Goliath fell, the men of Israel and of Judah arose and shouted and pursued the Philistines (1 Samuel 17:52). Soldiers who had been paralysed by fear found courage once one person stepped out in faith. Your obedience in one small area – a Bible study started, a sick neighbour helped, a bribe refused, a child taught to read – may encourage many others to rise.

A prayer

Lord God, You are a God of knowledge, and by Your actions are weighed. Thank You that Jesus came to seek and to save the lost, and that He went about teaching, preaching and healing. Forgive us where we have been careless, selfish or content to remain in ignorance. Open our eyes to the giants in our homes, churches, communities and nation, and give us courage like David's. Save the lost around us. Raise up servant leaders, and make us servants in every place where You give us authority. Teach us to work diligently and to show kindness to the poor. Heal the sick, bless every health worker, and help us to care for our bodies. Fill us with the knowledge of Your Word, and help us train the next generation. May all the earth know that there is a God who saves. In the name of Jesus Christ our Lord. Amen.

My commitment

Read these statements prayerfully and mark the ones you are ready to make your own.

- I will pray daily for people I know who are spiritually lost, and share the gospel with them as God gives opportunity.
- I will lead as a servant in my home, church and workplace, and I will refuse corruption in every form.
- I will work diligently, manage my money wisely and help the poor in ways that build their dignity.
- I will care for my health, use both prayer and good medical care, and show compassion to the sick.
- I will keep learning from God's Word, forgive quickly so that Satan gains no advantage, and help to educate the next generation.

- I will find my place in the work of planting churches, curing diseases and education.

Discuss together

1. Which of the five giants do you see most clearly in your community, and which do you find most frightening?
2. David put off Saul's armour because he had not proved it. What borrowed methods – copied from other places or other people – do churches sometimes try to use against these giants when simpler tools God has already given them would serve better?
3. What "smooth stones" has God already placed in your hands through your experience, training or circumstances?
4. What is one action from this whole study that you or your group will begin within the next month?
5. How will you encourage one another to keep going when progress seems slow?

The battle is the LORD's – take up your stones and go forward in His name.